

The Invasion of Abyssinia

Paper 1 Sample

These sources relate to the Abyssinia Crisis of 1935 - 36

Source I

Extract from the Covenant of the League of Nations, 1919

Article 16 - Should any member of the League resort to war in disregard of its covenants under Articles 12, 13 or 15, it shall be deemed to have committed an act of war against all other members of the League, which hereby undertake immediately to subject it to the severance [cutting of] of all trade or financial relations, the prohibition of all exchange between their nationals and the nationals of the covenant-breaking state, and the prevention of all financial, commercial or personal business between the nationals of the covenant-breaking state and the nationals of any other state, whether a member of the League or not.

It shall be the duty of the Council in such cases to recommend to the several governments concerned what effective military, naval or air force the members of the League shall contribute to the armed forces to be used to protect the covenants of the League.

Source J

Statement from a meeting between British Prime Minister, Stanley Baldwin, and a delegation of the League of Nations on 13 December 1935, marked "strictly confidential". www.nationalarchives.gov.uk

[The prime minister] assured us that he held faithfully to all his pledges with regard to the League and suggested that the interview should be both frank and confidential. The prime minister said that the League's policy is still the policy of the [British] government and we were all in agreement in desiring that the policy should be effective. Translating desire into action, however, raised extremely difficult questions.

He then explained the great gravity of the European situation, including the danger that Mussolini might make a "mad dog" [irrational] attack on the British fleet. Though the results of such an attack must in the long run be the defeat of Italy, the war might last some time and produce both losses and diplomatic complications of a serious kind. Meantime we were bound to consider whether we could rely on effective support from any other member of the League. No member except Great Britain had made any preparations for meeting an attack. As to France, the whole French nation had a horror of war.

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Source K

"Road from Rome", cartoon appearing in The New York Times depicting Mussolini during the Abyssinian Crisis, 6 October 1935.



"The Road from Rome"

Source L

Extract from *Africa in War and Peace* by Eric S Packham, 2004. The author, who was in Africa at the time of the Abyssinian Crisis, served in the British Army in the Gold Coast (Ghana) during the Second World War.

We all felt it was an ignominious [humiliating] ending to the high hopes which had been placed on the League of Nations when the Assembly refused to take the one decisive measure which would have halted the invasion - the prohibition of the exports of oil to Italy, without which Mussolini could not have supplied his invading forces ... In 1935 Laval's main foreign policy aim was to maintain an alliance with Italy, so it was more important to have Mussolini as an ally against Hitler than to defend Haile Selassie against him. Also Hoare and Laval apparently believed that Mussolini might go to war against Britain if Britain should impose an oil sanction against Italy or cut Italy's communications with Abyssinia ... In 1935 Britain was the leading power in Europe and should have accepted responsibility for taking the lead and dealing effectively with the Abyssinian situation. The other League members were not backward in imposing sanctions against Italy, but unfortunately Britain failed to give an effective lead until it was too late.

Questions

Question 1

- (a) What, according to Source I, was the significance of Article 16 of the Covenant of the League of Nations?
- (b) What does Source K reveal about Italian foreign policy in 1935?

Question 2

With reference to the origin, purpose and content, analyse the value and limitations of Source L for historians studying the Abyssinia Crisis

Question 3

Compare and contrast the views expressed in Sources J and L about British policy during the Abyssinia Crisis

Question 4

Using the sources and your own knowledge, discuss the reasons why the League of Nations' policy of collective security was difficult to apply in the Abyssinian Crisis.

Move to global war: The Invasion of Abyssinia student answer

Question 1

a. Firstly Article 16 aims to ensure security for all member states of the League of Nations by providing economic or military assistance to the state/s at risk. Secondly, Article 16 is significant because it is very strict on who is considered an 'enemy' (anyone breaking rules in Articles 12, 13 or 15). Finally, breaking rules in Articles 12, 13 or 15 would be immediately followed by ceasing all economic and/or national relations.

3/3 A clear, accurate, and concise response identifying all key elements of Article 16's significance, demonstrating precise understanding of collective security and League obligations.

b. Firstly, Source C shows that Mussolini is willing to go to war no matter what Italy's relationship with the League is, as shown by the paper in his hand which shows his blatant disregard for the league Secondly, the caption 'The Road from Rome' and the sign which points only one way implies that Mussolini's only choice of action is to go to war.

2/2 Clear points explained with reference to details in the cartoon

Question Two

One value of Source L arises from its origin as an extract written by Eric S. Packham, a British soldier who lived in Africa during the 1930s. His direct experience of colonial Africa gives the source first-hand regional insight into how the Abyssinia Crisis was perceived in British and African contexts. The purpose of the work—*Africa in War and Peace* (2004)—is reflective and historical, allowing the author to evaluate events with the benefit of hindsight and to connect the crisis to broader African and imperial developments. This enhances its

value for historians seeking a retrospective critique of British and League policies. Another value lies in its content, which is sharply critical of British and French caution in confronting Mussolini. The source explicitly blames Britain's failure to impose oil sanctions and France's desire to preserve an alliance with Italy, offering evidence of contemporary appeasement and strategic self-interest—central themes for historians studying the League's weakness.

However, the limitations stem partly from its origin and perspective. Packham was not in Abyssinia itself but in West Africa, and thus lacked direct observation of events in East Africa. The purpose of producing a general work on African conflicts also restricts depth: the Abyssinia Crisis forms only part of a broader narrative. Finally, its content is strongly critical of Britain, suggesting potential bias in emphasizing British culpability while underplaying wider systemic or geopolitical constraints.

4/4 A perceptive and well-balanced analysis that clearly integrates origin, purpose, and content to evaluate both the insight and the limitations of Source L; focused, precise, and fully contextualized.

Question 3

One similarity expressed in Sources J and L about British policy during the Abyssinia Crisis is Britain's fear of provoking an Italian attack as a major influence on policy. Source J records Prime Minister Baldwin's concern that Mussolini might make a "mad dog attack on the British fleet," explaining Britain's hesitancy to act. Similarly, Source L notes that British leaders such as Hoare and Laval feared "Mussolini might go to war against Britain if Britain should impose an oil sanction." A second similarity is that Britain was the only League member capable of acting militarily, highlighting its leading responsibility. In Source J, Baldwin admits that "no member except Great Britain had made any preparations for meeting an attack." Source L echoes this by asserting that "Britain was the leading power in Europe and should have accepted responsibility for taking the lead." A third similarity is the portrayal of Britain's policy as entangled with the wider European situation rather than focused solely on Abyssinia. Source J stresses "the great gravity of the European situation," implying Britain's decisions were conditioned by broader diplomatic risks. Source L likewise connects British restraint to France's desire "to maintain an alliance with Italy... against Hitler."

One difference expressed in Sources J and L about British policy during the Abyssinia Crisis is that Source J defends British policy as pragmatic and loyal to the League, while Source L condemns it as a moral failure. Source J reports that Baldwin "held faithfully to all his pledges with regard to the League," suggesting principled commitment tempered by realism. In contrast, Source L describes the outcome as "an ignominious ending to the high hopes placed on the League," directly blaming Britain's "failure to give an effective lead." A second difference is on the significance of sanctions as a test of British leadership. Source J never mentions specific sanctions and focuses on strategic caution. Source L, however, argues that "the prohibition of oil exports... would have halted the invasion," identifying the absence of oil sanctions as decisive proof of Britain's weakness.

5/6 A thoughtful, argument-driven comparison showing clear and valid points of similarity and difference; consistently analytical though not fully developed in depth across all five comparisons.

Question 4

The failure of collective security in the Abyssinian Crisis stemmed less from ignorance of principle than from the League's inability to reconcile idealism with the geopolitical, economic, and psychological realities of interwar Europe. Tension between legal obligation and political will was eventually revealed as member states accepted the moral language of the Covenant but recoiled from the practical consequences of enforcement.

The League's structural weakness made enforcement of its own covenant nearly impossible. Article 16 established that aggression against one member was aggression against all, but it relied on voluntary compliance rather than binding authority. Without a standing army or a mechanism to compel contributions, the League's "collective" security existed only at the discretion of national governments. In 1935 that

discretion was shaped by fear and fatigue, not resolve. Collective security was conceived as an international conscience, yet executed through sovereign hesitation.

That hesitation was most acute in London and Paris, whose leaders saw confrontation with Italy as strategically reckless. Baldwin's confidential remarks (Source J) betray the psychological residue of the First World War: the horror of renewed conflict and doubt over French reliability. Britain's fear of isolation and France's pacifism rendered decisive action politically untenable. Rather than embodying cowardice, as later critics suggested, such caution reflected a continent still traumatized by industrial slaughter. The Abyssinian Crisis was the event that exposed how collective security demanded a level of public endurance Europe no longer possessed.

Even where capability existed, priorities were **inverted by the changing balance of power**. By 1935, Mussolini's Italy was seen less as an aggressor than as a potential bulwark against Hitler. Packham's retrospective critique (Source L) rightly condemns this calculus as self-defeating, yet his outrage underscores a truth of the moment: policy was dictated by fear of Germany, not compassion for Abyssinia. The *Stresa Front* had linked Britain, France, and Italy in a fragile anti-Nazi alignment, and sanctioning Mussolini risked breaking it. The decision to withhold oil sanctions, the "one decisive measure" Packham identifies, illustrates how collective security collapsed under the weight of strategic realignment.

Economic **fragility** further eroded the League's authority. The Great Depression had left governments inward-looking, currencies unstable, and electorates hostile to new burdens. Sanctions threatened commercial recovery, and military intervention was financially unthinkable. Even if moral conviction existed, it lacked the fiscal foundation to act. In this sense, the League was an institution of the 1920s confronting a crisis of the 1930s that was, in essence, a moral architecture unsupported by economic capacity. The League's universality was also compromised by absence and exclusion. The United States never joined while Germany and the Soviet Union oscillated between isolation and suspicion. Without these major powers, enforcement mechanisms became parochial, dependent on Britain and France who were the very states least willing to risk their stability. The result was what historians often describe as *collective insecurity* which was an alliance of anxious nations safeguarding themselves through inaction.

Ultimately, the League's inability to enforce collective security reflected the **widening gap between its moral idealism and the political realities revealed by each source**. Article 16 (Source I) codified a vision of unity that presumed universal will, while Baldwin's comments (Source J) expose how fear and fractured alliances rendered that will absent. The *New York Times* cartoon (Source K) captures the futility of legal condemnation in the face of unrestrained power, and Packham's retrospective criticism (Source L) voices the disillusionment that hindsight made inevitable. Taken together, the sources trace a steady unraveling of conviction from principle to paralysis, illustrating that the League's greatest weakness was not confusion over what collective security meant, but the lack of governments prepared to bear its cost.

In the end, the Abyssinian crisis revealed that the League's system could articulate collective duty but not compel collective sacrifice. Legal language without coercive authority, diplomacy shaped by fear, and economies crippled by depression combined to hollow out the promise of 1919. The episode stands as proof that when security depends on unanimity among anxious powers, aggression is rewarded with delay, and principle collapses under caution. Collective security failed not in conception but in execution; a noble covenant undone by human reluctance to act upon it.

9/9 A sophisticated and cohesive discussion that synthesizes all four sources with wide and relevant contextual knowledge, sustaining a compelling argument on the structural and political limits of collective security; fully meets top-band descriptors.